



Waymo's flagbearer - the Chrysler Pacifica Hybrid

surroundings to the car's computers. That, along with the onboard cameras, sensors and computers, helped it gauge its way around without any possible human interference.

Firefly is particularly important for four reasons. One – it was the first car that Google really built for itself, in association with a few other companies of course. It stands as Google's first car that was used to show the fruits of its alleged \$1.1 billion investment in the segment till now, over eight years. Two – it not only became the face of Google's self-driving efforts, but of all autonomous car efforts worldwide. Three – it gave the world's first truly autonomous ride on public roads to a common citizen, when Steve Mahan, a legally blind person, was taken around without any supervision at all. And finally, it is the short-lived Firefly on which Google spun off its self-driving car project to Waymo – a completely independent entity under its parent, Alphabet.

Waymo, and the way forward

With most of the brunt work of establishment achieved, Waymo's present task is to teach the intricate bits to its cars. The company has initiated the ride-sharing model with its Pacifica minivans, has bid goodbye to the Firefly, which served as a noble prototype for testing, and is now engaged in making the cars practical outside of the pre-mapped, controlled roads.